
Phoenix Arise Foundation

Preventing Youth Exploitation and Trafficking Through Trauma-Informed, Play-Based Prevention and Early Intervention Programming

Submitted by: Phoenix Arise Foundation

Sector: Community Safety, Youth Prevention, Violence Prevention, Human Trafficking Prevention

1. Issue / Problem Statement

Across Canada, youth continue to fall through systemic gaps that increase vulnerability to human trafficking, exploitation, and long-term harm. While significant attention and resources are directed toward crisis response and extraction after exploitation has occurred, far less investment is made in primary prevention, early intervention, and long-term rebuilding.

Phoenix Arise Foundation approaches this challenge through the lens of a widely cited prevention metaphor:

Youth who experience food insecurity, unstable housing, unmet mental health needs, limited adult support, or disengagement from traditional education systems are at heightened risk of exploitation. Without accessible, engaging, and trauma-informed prevention programming, these youth remain vulnerable—not only to becoming victims of trafficking, but in some cases to being groomed into exploitative roles themselves.

2. Objectives

The primary objectives of this proposal are to:

1. Prevent youth from falling victim to human trafficking and exploitation through early, tailored, and engaging prevention education.
2. Identify and support youth at heightened risk by connecting them to immediate and longer-term supports.
3. Increase awareness and protective factors among youth, educators, community workers, and families.
4. Build scalable, adaptable prevention curriculum that can be shared with organizations and school boards across Canada.
5. Reduce long-term system costs associated with exploitation, criminal justice involvement, healthcare, and emergency interventions by investing upstream.

3. Proposed Initiative / Program Description

Phoenix Arise Foundation delivers trauma-informed, play-based, youth-centered workshops designed to meet youth where they are—academically, emotionally, socially, and developmentally.

Program Design and Delivery

Each workshop series is custom-designed prior to delivery. Phoenix Arise invests time upfront to:

- Consult with community workers, educators, parents, and frontline staff
- Understand learning styles, interests, hobbies, barriers, and challenges of participating youth
- Adapt incentives, activities, and materials to maximize engagement and retention

This preparatory work significantly increases participation, trust, and learning outcomes.

Workshop Structure

- Preferred duration: 8–12 weeks
- Minimum effective duration: 4 weeks
- Shorter workshops are offered when required, though Phoenix Arise has found programs under four weeks do not allow sufficient time to build trust, skills, or meaningful protective relationships.

Content Areas (Tailored Per Group)

Workshop content is adapted based on group needs and may include:

- Human trafficking awareness and prevention

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- Online safety and digital exploitation
 - Understanding consent and healthy relationships
 - Recognizing grooming tactics and vulnerabilities
 - Trauma responses (fight, flight, freeze, fawn) through role-play
 - Help-seeking skills and advocacy
 - Peer leadership and community responsibility

All programming is play-based and experiential, including debates, role-playing, creative storytelling, and interactive games. This approach ensures youth remain engaged, retain information, and are motivated to return.

4. Target Population / Beneficiaries

Primary beneficiaries include:

- Youth and young people experiencing social, economic, or emotional vulnerability
- Youth engaged with community programs, shelters, schools, and youth-serving organizations
- Youth at risk of exploitation, trafficking, or involvement in exploitative networks

Secondary beneficiaries include:

- Families and caregivers
- Educators and frontline workers
- Community organizations and school systems
- Broader public safety and health systems

5. Wraparound Supports and Early Intervention

Phoenix Arise does not limit its impact to workshop delivery alone. During programming, facilitators actively identify youth who may require additional support and provide:

- Nutritious meals at every session (recognizing that learning cannot occur on an empty stomach)
- Emergency assistance such as groceries, clothing, shoes, haircuts, transportation support
- Connections to mental health supports, including therapists, psychiatrists, peer support workers, crisis workers, and advocates
- Ongoing contact information so youth can reach out when they are ready for help

Each workshop series concludes with a small celebration to reinforce positive participation, relationship-building, and program completion.

6. Costs and Financial Considerations

- Average cost per workshop group: \$180-\$240
- Average group size: ~30 youth
- Costs include meals, incentives, materials, and facilitation
- Emergency supports (food, transportation, crisis intervention) are provided as needed and are not included in base workshop costs

This model represents a low-cost, high-impact prevention investment when compared to downstream costs associated with exploitation, justice involvement, healthcare utilization, and long-term social services.

7. Implementation Plan

Upon funding approval, Phoenix Arise will:

1. Expand workshop delivery across community organizations and youth-serving settings
2. Strengthen partnerships with schools, shelters, and service providers
3. Refine and document curriculum for scalability

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4. Collect qualitative and quantitative data on engagement, retention, and outcomes
 5. Prepare curriculum for broader dissemination and integration
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8. Long-Term Vision and Sustainability

Phoenix Arise's long-term goal is to embed trafficking prevention education into mainstream systems by:

- Sharing curriculum with organizations and school boards
- Supporting institutions to integrate content into existing programming
- Building a national prevention framework accessible to all youth

By shifting the focus upstream—toward prevention, education, and early support—this initiative aims to create lasting systemic change rather than reactive intervention.

9. Expected Outcomes

- Increased youth awareness of trafficking risks and protective strategies
- Improved help-seeking behaviour and earlier intervention

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- Reduced vulnerability to exploitation
 - Strengthened community capacity to recognize and respond to risk
 - Long-term cost savings across public systems